CCHU9081 · FIELD TRIP 2 · SELF-DESIGNED URBAN LEGEND TOUR

Five stories Sham Shui Po *tells about itself*

One district, five checkpoints, two hours on foot — and underneath every story, a document that says something slightly different.

5	120	1.5	Free
CHECKPOINTS	MINUTES	KM ON FOOT	NO BOOKING

HKU

FIRST-YEARS

Who this walk is for

And why a district you think you know is the right place to start.

This tour is designed for **HKU first-year students in their first semester**: people who know Sham Shui Po as the place with the cheap electronics street and the "poorest district" label, and who have never been inside Mei Ho House, up Bishop Hill, or through Dragon Centre.

They have heard the label but not the history. "Sham Shui Po is dangerous, poor, full of subdivided flats" is a media reputation; the same district is where Hong Kong built its public housing, its water supply and its second-hand economy. The gap between the label and the record *is* the tour.

And every stop asks them to do something they will do for the rest of their degree: check a claim against a source. These five stories are not exotic — they are the same moves as "this hall is haunted", "this building is about to be demolished", "everything on that street is stolen".

THE THEME

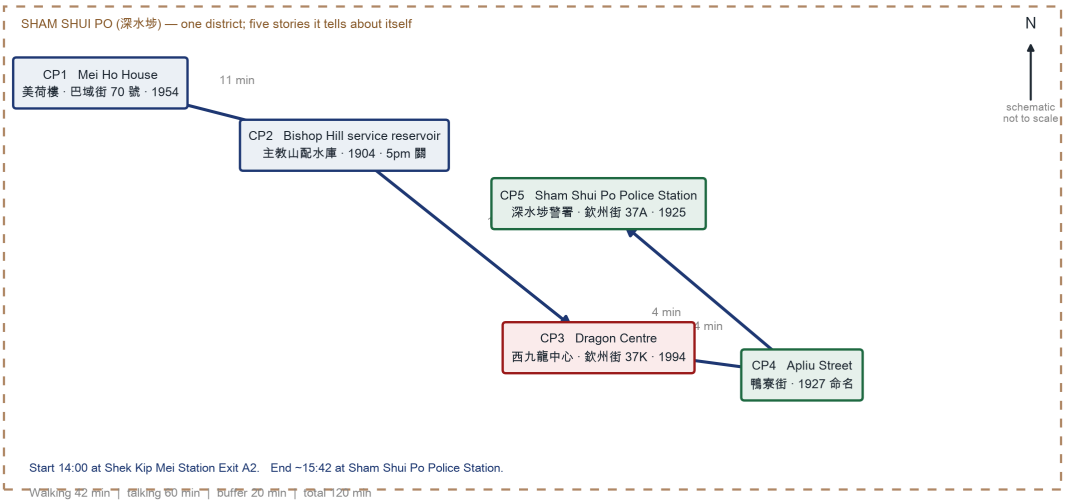
Five stories the district tells about itself — one rumour, one discovery legend, one ghost story, one commercial slander, one institutional legend. Most legend tours collect ghosts. This one collects **five different kinds of myth**, and shows that a single district produces all five.

WHAT MAKES IT DIFFERENT

Every checkpoint has a primary source you can check: a police file, a public works report, a gazette notice, a heritage grading. The tour never asks you to take a story on trust — it asks what the story is *for*.

The route

Shek Kip Mei Station to Yen Chow Street. Flat except one six-minute climb.



Map 1 — schematic, not to scale. Drawn for walkability rather than geography.

TIME	STOP / LEG	MIN
14:00	Meet — Shek Kip Mei Station, Exit A2. Briefing: the method, consent before photographing anyone, and which stops close early.	4′
14:04	Walk: Berwick Street → Mei Ho House	8′

TIME	STOP / LEG	MIN
14:12	CP1 · Mei Ho House	10′
14:22	Walk & climb: Woh Chai Hill path to the reservoir (last entry 16:30)	11′
14:33	CP2 · Bishop Hill service reservoir (closes 17:00)	13′
14:46	Walk: reservoir → Dragon Centre	15′
15:01	CP3 · Dragon Centre (西九龍中心)	10′
15:11	Walk: Dragon Centre → Apliu Street	4′
15:15	CP4 · Apliu Street	10′
15:25	Walk: Apliu Street → Yen Chow Street	4′
15:29	CP5 · Sham Shui Po Police Station	10′
15:39	Close — five kinds of myth, one-minute written reflection, Q&A	3′

Content 100 minutes (42 walking, 58 talking), then a 20-minute buffer: 120 minutes end to end. The reservoir is reached by 14:33, well before its 16:30 last entry; it closes at 17:00. Toilets at the station, at Mei Ho House and at Dragon Centre.

The five checkpoints

Story, record, reading — and the photograph to take at each one.

01 Mei Ho House 美荷樓

70 Berwick Street · Shek Kip Mei Estate, Block 41 · 1954

HISTORICAL MYTH — TWO OF THEM

THE STORY

Two stories are told about Christmas Night 1953. The first is a rumour that still circulates among residents: the fire was not an accident — somebody set it so that the squatters would be rehoused. The second is the version in every textbook: that the Shek Kip Mei fire created public housing, and the H-block estates were the government's answer to 58,000 people made homeless overnight.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

At about 21:30 on 25 December 1953 a man making shoes in Pak Tin Village overturned a kerosene lamp into a bucket of flammable plastic solution. The first 999 call was logged at 21:39. The fire covered 41 acres — about 23 football pitches — across six villages, destroyed 2,580 huts, killed 3 people, injured 51 and left close to 58,000 homeless. Within weeks the government began the first eight six-storey resettlement blocks. Mei Ho House, completed in 1954, is the only surviving H-shaped Mark I block, a Grade 2 historic building, and since December 2013 a youth hostel and the Mei Ho House Life Museum.

CLAIM & COUNTER-CLAIM

✕ **“Someone set the fire so people could be rehoused.”**

→ No evidence. Residents interviewed decades later give several versions — cooking, opium, arson; the police file records an accidental kerosene lamp. The rumour survives because it is a plausible account of a government nobody trusted.

✕ **“The fire created Hong Kong's public housing policy.”**

→ This is itself the subject of a book: Alan Smart's *The Shek Kip Mei Myth* (HKU Press, 2006) argues that mass public housing was already on the agenda, and the fire accelerated rather than caused it.

READING

> There are two myths here, and one of them is official. The residents' rumour compresses a structural failure — 300,000 squatters, no fire access, no housing policy — into a single villain. The textbook version compresses the same complexity into a single night, because a fire is easier to remember than a policy. The question is not which is true, but who needs which version.

The H-block façade and the block number
Block 41 corner, late afternoon light

The life museum entrance
The 1954 date and the museum sign in one frame

SOURCES Housing Authority estate history; police file as reported by CUHK student journalists; Alan Smart, The Shek Kip Mei Myth (HKU Press, 2006).

02 Bishop Hill service reservoir 主教山配水庫

Woh Chai Hill · built 1904 · free entry since 2024

DISCOVERY LEGEND

THE STORY

Before 2020 almost nobody knew there was a building inside Woh Chai Hill. The stories that grew in the weeks after it was exposed said it was a Japanese wartime tunnel complex, or an air-raid shelter, or a secret government facility; others said the government had known all along and was demolishing it quietly before anyone could object.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

The reservoir is part of the Kowloon Waterworks Gravitation Scheme, proposed in 1900–01 and completed on 10 August 1904. It is circular, underground, and built of red brick arches carried on 108 granite columns under a concrete ceiling; it was decommissioned in 1970. On 28 December 2020 demolition works exposed the structure, conservation groups and residents stopped the work, and the government apologised for its insensitivity — four columns had already been cut away. It was graded Grade 1 in June 2021 and opened free to the public on 1 August 2024, with self-guided audio tours by QR code and no booking needed for individual visitors.

CLAIM & COUNTER-CLAIM

✕ **“It is a Japanese wartime tunnel or air-raid shelter.”**

→ No. It is a 1904 water reservoir, documented in the government's own 1900–05 public works papers.

✕ **“The government knew and tried to demolish it in secret.”**

→ True in effect, not in intent: the Antiquities Office had never assessed it, the works were routine, and the government publicly apologised for the omission.

READING

This legend was created by an absence in the record, not by a lie. Nobody wrote the building into the heritage list, so when it appeared it had no official identity — and a

> structure with no official identity immediately acquires a folk one, because the public has to explain it somehow. The “Japanese tunnel” story is a placeholder. The real story is better: a hundred-year-old piece of infrastructure survived because it was forgotten, and was nearly destroyed for the same reason.

The red-brick arches and granite columns
Inside, during opening hours

The hillside entrance
Sign and path, so a reader can find it

SOURCES Kowloon Waterworks Gravitation Scheme public works papers (1900–05); Antiquities Advisory Board grading, June 2021; Water Supplies Department opening arrangements, 1 August 2024.

03 Dragon Centre 西九龍中心

37K Yen Chow Street · opened 1994

GHOST STORY — THE ROLLER COASTER THAT STOPPED

THE STORY

Dragon Centre is Sham Shui Po's one big shopping centre, and its most famous feature was the Dragon — Hong Kong's first indoor roller coaster, on the top floor. The story everyone repeats is that the roller coaster stopped because it was haunted: too many breakdowns, too many strange things, and a food court that feels wrong the moment you step into it. Some add a woman in red, or a jumper on an upper floor.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

Dragon Centre opened on 7 November 1994 (some sources date construction to 1993), at 37K Yen Chow Street. It is about nine storeys, a landmark of west Kowloon, and its facilities included Hong Kong's first indoor roller coaster, the Dragon, an ice rink on the 8th floor and a games floor on the 9th. The roller coaster later ceased operation. The centre is open 10:00–22:00 daily.

CLAIM & COUNTER-CLAIM

✕ **“The Dragon roller coaster stopped because it was haunted.”**

→ Its closure was a commercial decision — an indoor ride is expensive to run and ridership fell. No official or press record attributes the closure to anything supernatural; the haunting claim is a circulating story, not the reason.

✕ **“The centre is haunted; people have died there.”**

→ Accidents and deaths have been reported in and around the centre, as in many busy public spaces. “This building is haunted” is the act of joining separate incidents into one story — a pattern, not a fact.

READING

A shopping centre is a modern city's indoor public space, and when the crowds thin out, an empty atrium and a stopped fairground ride grow ghost stories on their own. This stop

> is the cleanest case on the tour: a ride that really did stop (the fact) plus a story that it stopped because it was haunted (the legend). People reach for the supernatural to explain a purely commercial decision, because “nobody wanted to ride it any more” is not a good enough story.

The atrium / former ride, shot down from an upper floor
Shows the empty central space

The centre's entrance or the floor guide
The name and the storey list in frame

SOURCES Dragon Centre official site (opening, floors); press coverage of the Dragon roller coaster and the centre's ghost stories.

04 Apliu Street 鴨寮街

Named in the Gazette, 25 November 1927

COMMERCIAL SLANDER

THE STORY

Everyone in Hong Kong has heard that the second-hand electronics on Apliu Street are stolen: the phones are wiped and resold, and if you buy a camera here it will be somebody's. The street is also called the “men's street”, on the assumption that only men come here to dig through boxes of components.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

In the nineteenth century this was sea, fish ponds and farmland, with duck sheds along the shore; the village of Ap Liu stood at the junction of Apliu Street and Kwun Yam Street today. It was cleared in the 1910s when Sham Shui Po was reclaimed and laid out, and the street was formally named in the Gazette on 25 November 1927 — 660 metres from Poplar Street to Yen Chow Street. From the 1930s it sold second-hand goods and was known as Kowloon's “Cat Street”; from the 1980s it became the electronics and components market. It now has around 200 stalls, part of a hawker area of some 985 pitches across ten streets in Sham Shui Po.

CLAIM & COUNTER-CLAIM

✕ **“Everything sold here is stolen.”**

→ False as a general claim. Individual cases occur in any second-hand market, but the trade is licensed hawking and legal resale, much of it ex-corporate and ex-export stock.

✕ **“It is a men's street.”**

→ The nickname is old; the customers are not. The crowd is mixed, and includes a large South Asian customer base.

READING

This is commercial slander doing useful work. Calling a street “all stolen” marks it as slightly illegal, which makes it faintly thrilling to visit and easier to look down on — and both reactions sell. The documented street is duller and more interesting: a reclaimed

> shoreline, a cleared village, a 1927 gazette notice, and a second-hand economy that recycled the city's electronics thirty years before “sustainability” was a policy word.

A stall run, with the vendor's permission
Ask first; a wide shot rather than a portrait

The street sign at the Yen Chow Street end
The 1927 name in frame

SOURCES Gazette notice, 25 November 1927; Sham Shui Po district history; hawker-area figures from the Food and Environmental Hygiene Department.

05 Sham Shui Po Police Station 深水埗警署

37A Yen Chow Street · built 1924–25

INSTITUTIONAL LEGEND

THE STORY

Station staff call it “the haunted station”. On the night of the Hungry Ghost Festival in 1995, so the story goes, officers and a person in custody saw something on the ground floor; the CCTV was said to have recorded it; and the matter was supposedly suppressed by senior officers.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

The station was begun in 1924 and completed in 1925, three storeys high, to police the rapid growth of Sham Shui Po as migrants arrived from the mainland. It was built beside the Sham Shui Po Barracks and what was then the seafront, and opened two years after Yau Ma Tei, the oldest surviving police station in Kowloon. It was graded Grade 3 in 1988 and upgraded to Grade 2 on 18 December 2009.

CLAIM & COUNTER-CLAIM

✕ **“The 1995 incident happened and was covered up.”**

→ No official record, no press report, no CCTV account in the public domain. It exists only in ghost-story books and websites.

✕ **“Police stations are a classic setting for ghost stories.”**

→ True as a pattern: institutions that hold people involuntarily, and where deaths and violence pass through, generate legend cycles in every city.

READING

The last stop is about institutions, not ghosts. A police station is the one building on this walk that a visitor cannot enter freely, that decides what happens to people inside it, and that controls its own record — precisely the combination that produces legend. The story's structure (something happened, the CCTV saw it, the seniors suppressed it) is a

story about distrust of record-keeping. It is the mirror of Stop 2, where a missing record created a Japanese tunnel: here, the claim is that the record exists and was hidden.

The 1925 façade from the public pavement
Yen Chow Street side, street sign in frame

A detail of the building
Windows or the entrance, no officers in frame

SOURCES Antiquities Advisory Board grading records (Grade 3, 1988; Grade 2, 2009); station history.

Sources, and what is not verified

A tour about record-keeping should show its own working.

WHERE THE FACTS COME FROM

- **Government and statutory records** — Housing Authority estate history and the police file on the 1953 fire; the 1900–05 public works papers for the Kowloon gravitation scheme; Antiquities Advisory Board grading papers; the Gazette notice of 25 November 1927.
- **Official statements** — the government's apology over the reservoir, the 2021 grading, and the 2024 opening arrangements.
- **Academic work** — Alan Smart, *The Shek Kip Mei Myth* (HKU Press, 2006).
- **Press and documentary** — coverage of the Dragon roller coaster's closure and of the centre's ghost stories.
- **Oral and online accounts** — estate walks, ghost-story channels, stallholders. Recorded as testimony, never as fact.
- **Site observation** — walking times, opening hours, which pavement the tour can stand on.

WHAT THIS TOUR DOES NOT CLAIM

- No newspaper database was searched, so “no record” means “none found in the sources consulted”.
- The 1995 police-station incident could not be traced beyond ghost-story books, and is presented as a circulating story, not an event.

- “Everything on Apliu Street is stolen” is a generalisation, not a fact: individual cases exist, the generalisation is stigma.
- No evidence supports the arson rumour of 1953 — but residents give several versions, and the versions are themselves the material.
- The Dragon roller coaster's “haunting” is a circulating story; no record links its closure to anything supernatural.
- Reservoir opening hours change; check before setting out.
- All photographs on this page are taken by the author on the route. Downloaded images are not used.

Five Myths of Sham Shui Po — a self-designed urban legend tour for CCHU9081 *Urban Legend: Fact, Myth and Reinterpretation*.

Chu Cheuk Ngai · UID 3036811625 · submitted 11 November 2026.